Sujin Lee

lee.9962@osu.edu ◇ (614) 736-8079 ◇ Personal Website
252 Bricker Hall, 190 N Oval Mall, Columbus, OH 43210
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Research Interests

Labor Economics, Applied Econometrics, Entrepreneurship

Education

The Ohio State University, Ph.D., Economics	2021-2027 (expected)
Seoul National University, M.A., Economics	2019-2021
Seoul National University, B.A., Economics	2015-2019

Working Papers

- "Beyond the Jack-of-All-Trades Hypothesis: The Importance of Business and Specialized Skills for Business Ownership Entry and Success," *Job Market Paper*

  Abstract: Lazear's well-known jack-of-all-trades (JOAT) model (2004, 2005) hypothesizes that business owners require balanced skills—an argument supported by numerous empirical studies, typically by showing that the number of prior occupations or employers held by workers is positively associated with business ownership. I extend the JOAT literature by arguing that (a) business owners do not need a balance of *all* skills, but instead need a set of *business* skills plus specialized skills relevant to their business; (b) business skills are likely to be more important for incorporated, capital-intensive, "advanced" businesses than for "basic" businesses; and (c) evidence in support of the JOAT hypothesis is likely to be sensitive to whether skill balance is measured directly or via orthodox, prior mobility measures. Using NLSY79 work histories linked to O*NET data to measure business skills, specialized skills, and skill balance, I find that all three arguments are supported by the data: business skills are strong predictors of entry into advanced (but not basic) business ownership; both business and specialized skills are associated with higher revenue and earnings for all business owners; and my direct measure of skill balance is unassociated with all three outcomes, whereas an orthodox (occupation count) measure strongly predicts entry into basic business ownership largely because it reflects involuntary job loss. In short, I find that business owners benefit from being jacks of business trades rather than jacks of all trades.

- "Can a High School Personal Finance Course Reduce the Gender Gap in Being Unbanked?"

  Abstract: Among unpartnered young adults in the United States—whose banking status reflects their own financial decisions rather than a partner's—women are significantly more likely than men to be unbanked, even after accounting for income and education. I determine whether state-mandated high school personal finance courses reduce this gender gap, and if so, through what mechanisms. Using the FDIC National Survey of Unbanked and Underbanked Households (2009–2023) and a heterogeneity-robust difference-in-differences estimator, I estimate that mandates reduce the likelihood of being unbanked for both women and men, but by significantly more for women, narrowing the gender gap by 42.9 percent. The effects are concentrated among women with no education beyond high school and among Black and Hispanic women—groups that face the greatest barriers to financial inclusion. I examine two mechanisms, and the evidence supports both. First, the mandates increase women's objective financial knowledge, although not their self-assessed knowledge. Second, the mandates increase self-employment among employed women, improve the likelihood of attaining middle-income status, and increase college completion. Because the mandates reach individuals before financial independence and

do not rely on voluntary participation, mandatory high school financial education can reduce persistent gender disparities in financial inclusion that adult financial education programs have struggled to address.

- "Restricting Large Firms to Protect Small Businesses: Evidence from Retail Operating-Day Restrictions" (with Marco Gonzalez-Navarro and Jaecheol Lee) *Under Review.*

  Abstract: Governments often try to protect small businesses by restricting larger rivals rather than subsidizing them directly. Whether such policies achieve their objectives depends on how much displaced demand is actually transferred to the intended beneficiaries, a question that requires tracing substitution toward other days, locations, or unregulated sellers, yet direct evidence on these margins remains limited. We study South Korea's policy requiring large retail chains to close two days per month, which provides predetermined variation in closure schedules across districts and weeks. Using high-frequency card-transaction data, we estimate that only 18 percent of displaced spending is redirected to small, independent retailers; larger shares are recouped by restricted chains on other shopping days or diverted to other unrestricted retail formats, many of them operated by large firms. Consistent with these limited transfers, we find no evidence that the policy improves the long-run survival of independent retailers. Mapping the observed substitution patterns into a discrete-choice framework identified by policy-induced variation in travel time to open stores, we estimate that the consumer welfare losses from restricted access are 2.7 times larger than the gains accruing to independent retailers. These findings suggest that restricting large firms can impose meaningful consumer costs while providing little durable support to the small businesses such policies are intended to protect.

Work in Progress

- "AI-Related Education Is Increasing and Widespread but Unequal" (with Saleh Zakerinia, Harrison Youn, Bruce Weinberg, Tian Lou, and Aiday Sikhova)

  Abstract: We examine the expansion of artificial intelligence (AI) education in higher education and its distribution across students. Using administrative student-level course enrollment records from Ohio public universities spanning more than two decades, we construct a novel measure of AI exposure. We identify AI-related courses using large language model (LLM) classifications of course descriptions and links to faculty engaged in AI research. To place the Ohio evidence in a broader context, we also classify AI-related fields of study by applying the same LLM-based approach to program descriptions and linking these classifications to Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS) data, allowing us to examine the growth and composition of AI degree programs nationwide. Our findings have implications for how higher education shapes the development of AI-related human capital while reinforcing disparities before students enter the labor market.

- "AI-Related Human Capital Inflows and Gender Composition in Firms" (with Tian Lou and Bruce Weinberg)

  Abstract: How does a business's exposure to AI influence gender disparities in its workforce? Building on the idea that AI technology is transmitted through human capital, we track AI-trained researchers to examine gender composition and wage gaps at firms that hire these researchers compared to those hiring researchers in non-AI fields within the same narrowly defined industries. Using UMETRICS data, which track payment records for all university research employees on grants, linked with Elsevier data on grant information, we measure a grant's "AI intensity" based on the AI publication activity of its principal investigators and an employee's "AI exposure" based on their duration and intensity of work on these AI-related grants. We then follow these researchers into the workforce using Ohio UI Wage Records and the Quarterly Census of Employment and Wages to identify businesses that are more likely to have

adopted advanced AI by hiring AI-trained researchers. We find that firms hiring AI-trained researchers have a lower share of female employees and wider gender pay gaps, even among non-AI-trained workers, compared to other firms in the same industries that do not hire AI-trained researchers. We also find a clear gradient based on how many AI-trained researchers firms hired as well as how much "AI exposure" AI-trained researchers had. These suggest that AI adoption can influence gender disparities across the broader workforce, beyond AI researchers and those directly involved in AI development or use.

- "Self-Employment Following Job Loss and Subsequent Career Trajectories"

  Abstract: Job displacement is a major labor market shock that often leads workers to pursue self-employment. Yet little is known about whether self-employment serves as a pathway back to stable employment or a persistent departure from wage work. In this paper, I examine the post-displacement labor market trajectories of workers who enter self-employment after job loss. Using the 1979 National Longitudinal Survey of Youth (NLSY79), I compare displaced workers who transition into self-employment with similar displaced workers who remain in wage employment. To improve comparability, I implement matching methods based on pre-displacement earnings, employment histories, demographic characteristics, and other labor market characteristics. I then examine differences in subsequent earnings, employment stability, the duration of self-employment, and transitions back to wage employment. The findings have implications on the role of self-employment in shaping workers' recovery following job displacement.

Pre-Doctoral Publications

- "The Effect of COVID-19 Stimulus Payments on Household Spending" (with Chulhee Lee), *Korean Journal of Social Policy*, 51, 2022, 60-88 (in Korean, non-peer reviewed).
- "The Effect of Child Support Payment Coupons in Response to COVID-19 on Household Spending" (with Chulhee Lee), *The Korean Journal of Economic Studies*, 69(3), 2021, 5-54 (in Korean).

Scholarships

University Fellowship, The Ohio State University, 2021-2022

Graduate Student Instructor Fellowship, Seoul National University, 2019-2021

Relevant Positions

Research Assistant to Professor Bruce Weinberg, The Ohio State University, SP 2024-present

Research Assistant to Professor Chulhee Lee, Seoul National University, SP 2019-SU 2021

Research Assistant to Professor Jisoo Hwang, Seoul National University, SP 2020-SU 2021

Research Assistant to Professor Sok Chul Hong, Seoul National University, FA 2020-SP 2021

Teaching Experience

Instructor of Record at The Ohio State University

Principles of Microeconomics (SU 2023)

Teaching Assistant at The Ohio State University

Principles of Microeconomics (FA 2023), Principles of Macroeconomics (FA 2023), Health Economics (FA 2022), Intermediate Microeconomic Theory with Calculus (FA 2022)

Teaching Assistant at Seoul National University

Population and Economy (FA 2019, FA 2020), Economic History (SP 2020)

Conference Presentations

2026 Federal Reserve Bank of Cleveland-Ohio State University Micro-Macro Workshop, Association for Public Policy Analysis & Management (scheduled)

2025 Southern Economic Association

2023 Decision Sciences Collaborative Spring Forum Poster Session (Ohio State University), North American Meetings of the Urban Economics Association, Bowling Green State University-Ohio State University Graduate Student Conference on Population

2020 Society for the Advancement of Socio-Economics Conference (virtual)

References

Prof. Audrey Light (Advisor)
Department of Economics
The Ohio State University
light.20@osu.edu

Prof. Bruce Weinberg
Department of Economics
The Ohio State University
weinberg.27@osu.edu

Prof. Meta Brown
Department of Economics
The Ohio State University
brown.991@osu.edu